

# "SCRIPTIO CONTINUA" IN EARLY HEBREW: ANCIENT PRACTICE OR MODERN SURMISE?

By A. R. MILLARD

Solution of textual problems in the Old Testament is attempted frequently by re-dividing the traditional sequence of letters on the ground that the words would not have been separated in ancient times. This practice of *scriptio continua* is constantly invoked or implied. Recent standard works on textual history give their authority; thus B. J. Roberts wrote, "Another source of textual corruption was the absence of word-division in the text in both the Canaanite and the Aramaic script, with a resultant possible divergent division of words and the consequent adoption of erroneous readings",<sup>1</sup> and D. R. Ap-Thomas expressed a widespread view when he wrote "...no great changes can be dated after the activities of Rabbi Akiba round about A.D. 100, if we except the separation of words by a small space, which helped considerably in the preservation of the existing text".<sup>2</sup>

Such definite pronouncements need to take into account contrary examples of ancient date, as B. J. Roberts has seen: "Word-division is frequently clearly indicated on the [Qumran] scrolls..." and "...there are indications in inscriptions from an early time that word-division was practised. The Ras Shamra tablets, the Siloam inscription, and the Lachish letters all show word-separation by means of a dot or perpendicular stroke at the end of words. Similarly the Samaritan Pentateuch shows a word-division, in this case by means of a dot, and the end of a sentence is marked by a colon."<sup>3</sup> Yet the same writer annotated the earlier sentence quoted, "This statement must stand in spite of the fact that the Jerusalem [i.e. Qumran] scrolls show a distinct word-division".<sup>4</sup>

<sup>1</sup> *The Old Testament Text and Versions* (Cardiff, 1951), p. 93

<sup>2</sup> *A Primer of Old Testament Text Criticism* (2nd ed. Oxford, 1964), p. 14, cf. pp. 41 ff. Cf. G. MacGregor, *The Bible in the Making* (London, 1961), p. 30. W. F. Albright has stated (*Christianity Today* xii (1968), 917), "...as a rule the Old Testament was originally written with only the consonants, and without spaces between words".

<sup>3</sup> *Op. cit.* p. 14.

<sup>4</sup> *Ibid.* p. 93 n. 4.

Earlier writers also took the inscriptional evidence into account. C. D. Ginsburg argued, "From the fact that both in the Inscription of Mesha and of Siloam the words are separated by a point, whilst in the Inscriptions on gems and coins, as well as those in Phoenician, there is generally no such separation, it is fairly concluded that originally the words were not strictly divided. . . This derives confirmation from the Massorah and the ancient Versions."<sup>1</sup> Friedrich Delitzsch less sweepingly concluded that *scriptio continua* was confined to the "square" script.<sup>2</sup> Each writer gives examples of improved sense resulting from re-division, and the weight of these solutions cannot be gainsaid.

However, a review of the topic seems opportune, for the number of early documents available, greatly increased in recent years, enables a good deal to be learnt about the conventions of the scribes in this particular. Furthermore, I. O. Lehman has tried to establish "the fact that the same consonants may be connected both with the word preceding and that following it" as a principle for text study, terming it "the textual ambivalence of Hebrew consonants". He has claimed that it "was known from the sixth pre-Christian to the first Christian century in all traditions".<sup>3</sup>

*Scriptio continua* is well-known from Greek manuscripts and epigraphs of the Hellenistic and Roman periods, when it was the norm, although Latin inscriptions and documents commonly separate each word by a point.<sup>4</sup> The earliest specimens on papyrus belong to the fourth and third centuries B.C., but writings on more durable surfaces from the classical age exhibit the same habit. Nevertheless, among the archaic Greek inscriptions, nearest in time to the advent of the alphabet from the East, there are examples of word-division by points, although L. H. Jeffery has concluded that "punctuation does not appear in any of the earliest inscriptions except that from Pithekoussai [Ischia, c. 700 B.C.]; it seems to have taken root in the course of the seventh century, and thereafter to have been used in some states often (Crete, Attica, Argos, Lakonia), and hardly at all in others (Corinth, Elis)".<sup>5</sup> Despite its ephemeral nature the use of this

<sup>1</sup> *Introduction to the Hebrew Bible* (London, 1897), p. 158.

<sup>2</sup> *Die Lese- und Schreibfehler im alten Testament* (Berlin and Leipzig, 1920), p. 1.

<sup>3</sup> *J.N.E.S.* xxvi (1967), 93-101.

<sup>4</sup> Cf. E. G. Turner, *Greek Papyri: An Introduction* (Oxford, 1968), p. 57; B. M. Metzger, *The Text of the New Testament* (2nd ed. Oxford, 1968), pp. 12-13.

<sup>5</sup> *The Local Scripts of Archaic Greece* (Oxford, 1961), p. 50.

feature in early Greek is of some relevance for the conclusions of our inquiry. More value attaches to the senior scripts of the Levant, and they deserve detailed scrutiny.

Changes in script and the nature of the surviving material make division of the West-Semitic alphabetic texts into two main periods reasonable and convenient. No sharp break is presupposed by this distinction; rather, its coincidence with the Persian triumph marks the real start of the alphabet's world conquest.

#### A. THE EARLIER ALPHABETIC TEXTS

Documents older than c. 600 B.C. now extant are few compared with those from the later era, but their diversity demands as complete a survey as possible before any deductions about word-division may be made.<sup>1</sup> The vehicle of the text inevitably affects the ductus to some extent. "Lapidary" and "cursive" forms may be distinguished on occasion,<sup>2</sup> but too hard a line should not be drawn between the two until more can be learnt about the work of the professional scribe; for it may be assumed that one who wrote on papyrus, parchment, or potsherd might also make a draft for the seal-engraver or the mason. Damage to many of the pieces listed, too, means that small details are lost, and such may be the case where editors have been unable to show word-dividers with any consistency (e.g. the Siloam tomb inscription under 3 A a below, or the Lachish ostraca under 3 A c). Moreover, in cursive documents rapidly written in ink, the points were liable to obliteration by the following letter,<sup>3</sup> or to attachment to the previous one.<sup>4</sup> Simple names with patronyms have been

<sup>1</sup> Special abbreviations used are:

*D* D. Düringer, *Le Iscrizioni antico-ebraiche palestinesi* (Florence, 1934).

*DJD* M. Baillet, D. Barthelemy, P. Benoit, J. T. Milik, R. de Vaux, *Discoveries in the Judaean Desert*, I-III (Oxford, 1955, 1960, 1962).

*KAI* H. Donner, W. Röllig, *Kanaanäische und aramäische Inschriften* (2nd ed. Wiesbaden, 1968-9), texts cited by number.

*M* S. Moscati, *L'Epigrafia ebraica antica 1935-1950* (Rome, 1951).

*SS III* G. M. Crowfoot *et al.*, *Samaria-Sebaste: III, The Objects* (London, 1957).

<sup>2</sup> Cf. J. Naveh, *H.T.R.* LXI (1968), 71.

<sup>3</sup> As H. Michaud remarked in *Syria* XXXIV (1957), 41. There may be examples in Arad ostraca 1, line 5; 2 line 1, judging by the published photographs.

<sup>4</sup> See J. T. Milik, *R.B.* LVI (1959), 551. Lachish letter 4, line 3, may be read כתבתני על, the point having run on to the upper bar of the *yodb*; compare the points following *yodb* in lines 4 and 5.

omitted from the survey because division of words in marks of ownership is considered less necessary, although a proportion of seals do exhibit dividers (e.g. Hebrew seals *D* nos. 37, 38, 47, 53, 104; *M* nos. 21, 39) and some have been included where longer texts are scarce.

# 1. *Canaanite*

No word-divider is found in the texts from Sinai or their relatives from Palestine.<sup>1</sup> In the slightly later Lachish Ewer F. M. Cross has detected one in the form of three dots placed vertically above each other.<sup>2</sup>

# 2. *Phoenician*

## A. *Word-division present*

(i) by short vertical strokes:

Byblos texts (*KAI* 1, 3–8, sporadic in 2, Taf. I, II)

Cyprus "Honeyman" stone (*KAI* 30, Taf. III)

Chytroi fragment<sup>3</sup>

Nora text 2 (*CIS* I 145)

Arslan Tash conjuration (*KAI* 27)

(ii) by points:

Praeneste bowl (*CIS* I 164 B)

Ur ivory lid (*KAI* 29)

Chatal Hüyük spindle whorl (S. Gevirtz, *J.N.E.S.* XXVI (1967), 13–16)

(iii) by spacing:

Karatepe statue (*KAI* 26 C), upper gate (*KAI* 26 B, less carefully done)<sup>4</sup>

The relative particle, prefixed prepositions, and in some cases bound forms are not separated, e.g. Ahiham sarcophagus (*KAI* 1) *וּפְעַל בְּמַלְכָּם, גִּבְל מֶלֶךְ גִּבְל*, but contrast *גִּבְל מֶלֶךְ-גִּבְל* in Eli-ba'al and Shipti-ba'al (*KAI* 6, 7), although the latter has *גִּבְל גִּבְל*.<sup>5</sup>

## B. *No division*

Tell Sukas graffito (P. J. Rijs, *A.A.S.* XI–XII (1961–2), 141 and fig. 13, drawing only)

<sup>1</sup> W. F. Albright, *The Proto-Sinaitic Inscriptions and their Decipherment* (Harvard, 1966), p. 8.

<sup>2</sup> *B.A.S.O.R.* CXXXIV (1954), 20.

<sup>3</sup> See J. B. Peckham, *The Development of the Late Phoenician Scripts* (Cambridge, Mass. 1968), p. 15 n. 15.

<sup>4</sup> A. Dupont-Sommer, *R.A.* XLII (1948), 161–88; *J.K.F.* I (1950), 296–7.

<sup>5</sup> Cf. W. Röllig's remarks, *KAI* II, 2.

Karatepe lower gate (*KAI* 26 A)  
 Gold sheath of Kilamuwa from Zinjirli (*KAI* 25)  
 Bronze bowls from Cyprus (*KAI* 31)  
 Nora stone (*KAI* 46, Taf. II)

### 3. Hebrew

#### A. Word-division present, by points

##### a. Monumental inscriptions

Samaria stele (*M*, p. 114)  
 Siloam tunnel (*M*, p. 40)  
 Siloam tombs (N. Avigad, *I.E.J.* III (1953), 137-52; V (1955), 163-6, the latter doubtful)  
 Nimrud ivory plaque (*Iraq* XXIV (1962), 45-9)

##### b. Papyrus document

Wadi Murabba'at (J. T. Milik, *DJD* II, 93-100)

##### c. Ostraca

Arad (Y. Aharoni, *I.E.J.* XVI (1966), 1-7; *B.A.* XXXI (1968), 1-32, figs. 1, 9, 11, on the obverse only of the third; *Eretz Israel* IX (1968), 10-21, nos. 4-6, no. 6, a list, has a divider only in the first line)  
 Lachish (D. Diringer, in O. Tufnell, *Lachish III* (London, 1953), pp. 331-9)  
 Ophel (J. T. Milik, *R.B.* LVI (1959), 550-3)  
 Qasile no. 2 (*M.* p. 113, no. 11)  
 Samaria 1-63 (*D.* pp. 21-68)  
 Yavneh Yam letter (*KAI* 200, Taf. XXXI; F. M. Cross, *B.A.S.O.R.* CLXV (1962), 42-6)

##### d. Graffiti

Gibeon jar-handles, the majority (J. B. Pritchard, *Hebrew Inscriptions and Stamps from Gibeon* (Philadelphia, 1959); *B.A.S.O.R.* CLX (1960), 2-6)  
 Hazor "Peqah" jar (Y. Yadin, *Hazor II* (Jerusalem, 1960), pp. 73-4)  
 Samaria figurine (*SS* III, pp. 16-17)  
 Susa jar (*D.* pp. 285-7)

#### B. No division

##### a. Ostraca

Arad no. 3, reverse  
 Lachish no. 20

Qasile no. 1 (*M.* p. 113, no. 10, there is a single point in line 2)

Samaria C 1101, 1120 (*JS III*, pp. 11-16, 20-1)

b. *Graffiti*

Gezer calendar (*D*, pp. 1-20; *M*, pp. 8-26; sentence divisions within lines 1 and 2 are noted by a vertical stroke, all others fall at the ends of the lines)

Gibeon handles nos. 11, 14, 19, 26, 28, 34, 37-40, 42, 54, 55, 61

Lachish tomb text (*J. Naveh, I.E.J.* XIII (1963), 74-92)

In the Lachish ostraca the bound form חזי יהוה is found as חיהוה (3: 9), but also as חזי יהוה (6: 12), and וריאמר (3: 8) stands for ורי יאמר, features often employed to substantiate emendation on the grounds of *scriptio continua*. In Qasile ostrakon no. 2 בית חרן is undivided, and the first Arad ostrakon has שם הים similarly. Bound forms are not separated in the Yavneh Yam ostrakon (e.g. דבר עבדך line 2) and there are certain other words undivided, such as the verb and adverb in lines 5, 7, ואסם כימם.

4. *Ammonite*

A. *Word-division present*

'Ammān Citadel inscription (*S. H. Horn, B.A.S.O.R.* CXCIII (1969), 2-13; *F. M. Cross, ibid.* pp. 13-19)

'Ammān Theatre fragment (*R. Dajani, A.D.A.J.* XII-XIII (1967-8), 65-7, pl. XXXIX, by stroke)

Tell Deir 'Allā text (*H. J. Franken, V.T.* XVII (1967), 480-1)

Seals of Adoni-nur (*P.E.F.A.* VI (1953), pl. VI), Mannu-ki-Inurta (*N. Avigad, I.E.J.* XV (1965), 222-8, after first word)

B. *No division*

'Ammān statue (*R. D. Barnett, A.D.A.J.* I (1951), 34-6)

Adonipelet seal (*D*, no. 98), other seals (*A. Reifenberg, Ancient Hebrew Seals* (London, 1950), nos. 27, 35, 36, 40); *P.E.F.A.* VI, pl. VI; *P. Hammond, B.A.S.O.R.* CLX (1960), 38-41)

In the 'Ammān Citadel inscription bound forms are not divided, neither are nouns related by a preposition, nor are infinitive absolutes from finite verbs (e.g. מת ימתן in line 2, following *F. M. Cross*).

### 5. *Moabite*<sup>1</sup>

Word-dividers are found in all three monumental texts; short vertical strokes in the Kerak stele, points in the Mesha' and Dibon stones.

In each specimen bound forms may be separated, thus מלך·מאב, but ]מלך (Mesha', line 1). Occurrences of the short vertical stroke on the Mesha' stele have been analysed by F. I. Andersen who concluded that the strokes define parallel sentences.<sup>2</sup>

### 6. *Edomite*

Word-division by points is evident on the Umm el-Biyāra ostracon (J. T. Milik, in C. M. Bennett, R.B. LXXIII (1966), 398–9), but absent from the royal and other seals (*ibid.* pp. 399–401, nn. 54, 55).

### 7. *Early Aramaic*

#### A. *Word-division present*

##### (i) by short vertical strokes:

Tell Halaf altar (*KAI* 231)

Bar Hadad stele (*KAI* 201)

Zakir stele (*KAI* 202, Taf. XIII, XIV)

Bar Rakib's seal and ingots (F. von Luschan, W. Andrae, *Die Kleinfunde von Sendschirli* (Berlin, 1945), Taf. XXXVIII b, 58 t, u, v)

##### (ii) by points:

Hama brick (*KAI* 203)

Hazael ivory from Arslan Tash (*KAI* 232)

Zinjirli texts,

Kilamuwa stele (*KAI* 24, Taf. XXVII, Aramaic script, Phoenician dialect)

Hadad statue (*KAI* 214)

Bar Rakib's inscriptions (*KAI* 215–18, Taf. XII, XXXII)

Fragments (*KAI* 219–21)

Tell Halaf docket 4 (J. Friedrich *et al.*, *Die Inschriften von Tell Halaf* (Berlin, 1940), pp. 76–7, Taf. XXXI)

Nineveh dockets, some (L. Delaporte, *Epigraphes araméens* (Paris, 1912), nos. 8?, 11, 14, 15, 18?, 21, 23, 27, 30, 31)

Nimrud ostracon (J. B. Segal, *Iraq* XIX (1957), 139–45)

<sup>1</sup> See F. I. Andersen, *Or.* XXXV (1966), 81–120, and references on p. 81 n. 1.

<sup>2</sup> *Ibid.* pp. 85–8.

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Assur docket (*KAI* 236)

Luristan plaque (A. Dupont-Sommer, *Iranica Antiqua* iv (1964), 108–111)

Luristan cup (*ibid.* pp. 111–15)

### (iii) by spacing:

Adon letter (*KAI* 266, Taf. xxxiii)

Sefireh tablet (*KAI* 227, cf. J. Starcky, *Syria* xxxvii, 100, erratic)

Nērab stela (*KAI* 225, 226, Taf. xxiv, xxv, slight only)

Tell Halaf dockets (J. Friedrich, *op. cit.* pp. 70–8)

Assur ostrakon (*KAI* 233, Taf. xxvi)

Assur dockets, some (*KAI* 234, 235)

Luristan cup (A. Dupont-Sommer, *loc. cit.* pp. 115–18)

### B. No division

Sefireh stela (*KAI* 222–4, Taf. xv–xxiii)

Nineveh dockets, some (L. Delaporte, *op. cit.* nos. 7, 12, 19, 24, 25, 26, 32)

Nimrud ivory ND 8184 (a) (*Iraq* xxiv (1962), 43)

Hazael ivory from Nimrud (M. E. L. Mallowan, *Nimrud and Its Remains* (London, 1966), II, 598)

## B. LATER TEXTS

The abundance of material in many sections of this category permits general statements to be made.

### 1. Late Phoenician and Punic

The very large number of inscriptions on stone from the Mediterranean coastlands are written without any break between words. There are a few exceptions from Cyprus belonging to the fourth or third centuries B.C. (*CIS* I, 46, 49, from Kition, 89, 91, 92, from Idalion). An additional feature has been noticed by Z. S. Harris, "In CYPRUS two like consonants were often written as one... it takes place even in sandhi: אדמלכּ for אדן מלכּ [CIS I, 95]; מלכתי for מלך כתי [CIS I, 11] (the full forms being, however, more common)".<sup>1</sup>

### 2. Hebrew

Adoption of the Aramaic "square" script during or soon after the Exile did not result in the immediate extinction of the older

<sup>1</sup> *A Grammar of the Phoenician Language* (New Haven, 1936), p. 30.



"Phoenician" form, as the Qumran manuscripts have proved.<sup>1</sup> Accordingly, the two scripts are treated separately within this section.

*A. Texts in "Phoenician" script*

(i) Word-division present, by points:

Qumran biblical manuscripts

1QLev (*DJD* I, pls. VIII, IX)

2Q5(Lev) (*DJD* III, pl. XII, 5)

6Q1(Gen) (*ibid.* pl. XX, 1)

6Q2(Lev) (*ibid.* pl. XX, 2)

4Qpalaeo Ex<sup>m</sup> (P. W. Skehan, *J.B.L.* LXXIV (1955), 182-7)

Exodus fragment (S. A. Birnbaum, *The Hebrew Scripts* (London, 1954-7), no. 32)

(ii) No division:

Coins of the Hasmonians (see Y. Meshorer, *Jewish Coins* (Tel Aviv, 1967))

Coins of the First Revolt (*ibid.*) and coins of the Second Revolt also.

*B. Texts in "square" script*

(i) Words divided by spacing:

Qumran manuscripts generally

Nash papyrus (S. A. Cook, *P.S.B.A.* xxv (1903), 35; G. R. Driver, *The Hebrew Scrolls* (London, 1951), pl. II)

(ii) No division:

Bene Hezir Tomb (M. Lidzbarski, *Handbuch der Nordsemitischen Epigraphik* (Weimar, 1898), Taf. XLIII. 2)

Copper scroll from Qumran (*DJD* III, pls. XLV ff.)

Phylacteries from Qumran (*ibid.* pls. XXXII, XXXIII)

3. Aramaic

*A. Word-division present, by spacing*

a. Monumental inscriptions

from Egypt, e.g. Saqqara (*KAI* 267)

from Jerusalem, Uzziah plaque (E. L. Sukenik, *P.E.Q.* (1931), pp. 217-21)

<sup>1</sup> For the script and its development see R. S. Hanson, *B.A.S.O.R.* CLXXV (1964), 26-42.

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from Anatolia, e.g. Sardis (*KAI* 260); Daskyleion (A. Dupont-Sommer, *C.R.A.I.B.L.* (1966), p. 48)

##### b. *Papyri from Egypt*

Edfu (A. H. Sayce, A. E. Cowley, *P.S.B.A.* xxix (1907), pls. I, II, after p. 272)

Elephantine (A. H. Sayce, A. E. Cowley, *Aramaic Papyri Discovered at Assuan* (London, 1906), p. 15)

Hermopolis (E. Bresciani, M. Kamil, *Le lettere aramaiche di Hermopoli* (Rome, 1966), plates)

Saqqara (N. Aimé-Giron, *Textes araméens d'Égypte* (Cairo, 1931), plates, some from other sites)

##### c. *Leather documents found in Egypt, but despatched from Babylon or Susa in some cases* (G. R. Driver, *Aramaic Documents* (Oxford, 1954), plates)

##### d. *Ostraca*

from Egypt, e.g. *KAI* 270, Taf. xxv; A. Dupont-Sommer, in D. W. Thomas, W. D. McHardy, *Hebrew and Semitic Studies Presented to G. R. Driver* (Oxford, 1963), plate facing p. 53

from Babylonia, e.g. A. Dupont-Sommer, *R.A.* XL (1945-6), 143-7

from Persepolis, on stone objects, R. N. Frye, *The Heritage of Persia* (London, 1962), pl. 44.

##### B. *No division*

Tema stela (*KAI* 228-30; J. B. Segal, *Iraq* xxxi (1969), 170-3)

Bahadırli inscription (*KAI* 278)

Gözne Boundary inscription (*KAI* 259; R. S. Hanson, *B.A.S.O.R.* cxcii (1968), 9-11)

Keseçek Köyü stone (R. S. Hanson, *ibid.* pp. 3-5)

#### C. DIVISION OF WORDS IN OTHER SCRIPTS

To complete this survey and lend strength to the conclusions drawn it is appropriate to observe the usage of various other ancient scripts.

While it is not regularly employed in the Cretan "Linear A" and related texts, a vertical stroke divides words on the "Linear B" documents, the Cypro-Minoan texts, and their Cypriot

descendants, for the most part.<sup>1</sup> Groups of signs are separated in the same way on the Phaistos Disk.<sup>2</sup> On the mainland, the "Byblian" inscriptions include only two examples showing word-division.<sup>3</sup> Hieroglyphic Hittite often delimits words by strokes or, in the later period, marks them off with a special sign.<sup>4</sup>

The majority of alphabets derived directly or indirectly from the Canaanite forms and used in the first millennium B.C. distinguish the words. The Anatolian systems of Lycia and Phrygia have dots one above the other, Lydian and Sidetic space the words, Carian often has a vertical stroke, and the scripts of Italy usually employ points.<sup>5</sup> The South Arabian inscriptions invariably divide the words with a vertical stroke.<sup>6</sup>

Ugaritic cuneiform, apparently basically inspired by the Canaanite script, has a small wedge between words, although there are occasional exceptions, noticeably more in the non-literary tablets.<sup>7</sup>

Finally, at opposite ends of the ancient world, the Old Persian cuneiform syllabary divides words by an oblique wedge, and the Numidian alphabet employs a point.<sup>8</sup>

#### D. THE PRACTICE OF WORD-DIVISION

The foregoing lists demonstrate that word-division was normal amongst the majority of West-Semitic scribes. When the practice first arose cannot be said at present. Ugaritic usage may have been stimulated by a precursor of the early Phoenician (Byblos), or have copied from texts earlier than any now known, or the reverse may have happened (for a possible Canaanite indication

<sup>1</sup> M. Ventris, J. Chadwick, *Documents in Mycenaean Greek* (Cambridge, 1956), pp. 47 f. O. Masson, *Les Inscriptions chypriotes syllabiques* (Paris, 1961), pp. 68 ff.

<sup>2</sup> See R. W. Hutchinson, *Prehistoric Crete* (Harmondsworth, 1961), pp. 66-70, pl. 14b.

<sup>3</sup> M. Dunand, *Byblia Grammata* (Beirut, 1945), pp. 73-4, 82-3.

<sup>4</sup> E. Laroche, *Les Hiéroglyphes Hittites*, I (Paris, 1960), 252, 256.

<sup>5</sup> See J. Friedrich, *Kleinasiatische Sprachdenkmäler* (Berlin, 1932) and *Extinct Languages* (London, 1962), for illustrations and comments.

<sup>6</sup> A. F. L. Beeston, *A Descriptive Grammar of Epigraphic South Arabian* (London, 1962), p. 3.

<sup>7</sup> C. H. Gordon, *Ugaritic Textbook* (Rome, 1965), p. 30. S. Segert, in L. Rost, *Von Ugarit nach Qumran* (Berlin, 1958), p. 196; *Z.A.T.W.* LXXI (1959), 26.

<sup>8</sup> J. Friedrich, *Extinct Languages*, gives examples.

see § A 1 above). Another pointer to early use could be drawn from the South Arabic script, diverging in the fourteenth or thirteenth centuries B.C., if it took the idea of a divider with it, but no South Arabian inscriptions from so remote a date have yet been found.<sup>1</sup> Not until the opening of the first millennium B.C. is there definite evidence of the habit in the circles writing in any form of the alphabet.

Lack of dividers was no great drawback in Babylonian cuneiform, which, with its rich provision of syllabic signs, was able to express the whole phonetic sequence of a word, consonants and vowels, without difficulty (phrases and sentences were habitually divided in the very early texts, and words were seldom split between lines, an oblique wedge drawing attention to this unusual event). Likewise the Egyptian custom of adding determinatives and phonetic complements helped the reader to isolate individual words. Presumably word-dividers became a part of the systems of the Minoans, Cypriots, Hittites, and Persians because less precision was feasible with the simple syllabic signs (consonant + vowel). As the early alphabetic scripts, Canaanite-Phoenician and Ugaritic, allowed still less explicitness by representing consonants solely (or perhaps consonants + any vowel),<sup>2</sup> a mark of division was an even greater aid. The widespread use of separation can be taken to indicate that this was realized. Only with the development of a truly adequate alphabet by the Greeks did the need disappear and, eventually, the marks of division. (The curious retention of points in Latin inscriptions of the Republic and Empire is attributable to scribal conservatism.) Thus hindsight would prefer to place the introduction of separators close to the adoption of the alphabet to express a Semitic dialect.

The absence of division from various texts within groups where it is well attested should be regarded as the exceptions that prove the rule. Most of the cases are minor texts, notes of ownership which hardly demand separation by reason of their simplicity (albeit a number of specimens do have marks of division), lists of names, accounts and graffiti. Only the Sefireh stelae (A 7 B) a few later Aramaic inscriptions (examples in B 3 B), and the late Phoenician and Punic texts fall outside that range. They do, indeed, constitute a problem hard to clarify. Provincial or in-

<sup>1</sup> For the date of the divergence see W. F. Albright, *B.A.S.O.R.* CLXXII (1963), 54, and previously CXXXVIII (1955), 50.

<sup>2</sup> I. J. Gelb, *A Study of Writing* (2nd ed. Chicago, 1963), pp. 147-53.

experienced scribes may account for the two former.<sup>1</sup> The Aramaic advance in the representation of final, and also medial, vowels of certain types supplied another means for distinguishing some words,<sup>2</sup> a step forward shirked by Phoenician (sporadic occurrences are known in Punic).

#### E. WORD-DIVISION AND THE OLD TESTAMENT TEXT

The significance of our inquiry for Old Testament textual criticism is plain: *scriptio continua* was not a practice of early Hebrew scribes. Statements like C. D. Ginsburg's given earlier are belied by the physical existence of numerous documents. Actual biblical manuscripts older than the Qumran scrolls may be lacking, but the weight of evidence is heavily in favour of the view that their writers employed word-division in the form of points or spaces according to the script. This is not a denial that scribes ever made mistakes of division—the text-book examples in Isaiah ii. 20, Amos vi. 12 remain standard—but a denial that the assumption of *scriptio continua* can be used freely to impute errors to the ancient copyists. Two factors may be discerned leading to that assumption. The first is an internal one, the certain presence of errors resulting from mistaken division, as just noted, detected in the Hebrew text from the sense or from the ancient versions (yet even here advances in understanding of Hebrew syntax and of the versions give cause for re-assessment).<sup>3</sup> The second factor is speculative, that there has been an unconscious transference of Greek custom to Hebrew scribes, a transference easily made by scholars who were first trained in the classical tradition, or who approached the Old Testament from a prior acquaintance with the text of the New.<sup>4</sup>

Our conclusion is not new; there have been authoritative

<sup>1</sup> See J. Starcky's comments on the various sign-shapes in A. Dupont-Sommer and J. Starcky, *Les Inscriptions araméennes de Sfiré* (Paris, 1958), p. 133.

<sup>2</sup> F. M. Cross, D. N. Freedman, *Early Hebrew Orthography* (New Haven, 1952), pp. 32–3.

<sup>3</sup> Notice in this particular the characterization of the Septuagintal word-division by J. Barr, *Comparative Philology and the Text of the Old Testament* (Oxford, 1968), pp. 209, 266–7.

<sup>4</sup> Seen in the addition of "...in the ancient world there were no spaces between the words" in the fifth edition of Sir Frederick Kenyon's *Our Bible and the Ancient Manuscripts*, revised by A. W. Adams (London, 1958), p. 51, compare previous editions (fourth, 1939), p. 19 (also 5th ed. p. 74, cf. 4th ed. p. 41).

voices asserting that the early copies of the Hebrew books did have their words separated. S. R. Driver ended his discussion of early Hebrew orthography with the opinion that division could be inferred, while F. Buhl, H. Bauer and P. Leander, E. Würthwein, and M. Noth all noted the witness of the ancient texts against the likelihood of continuous writing.<sup>1</sup>

There are a sufficient number of early texts for some principles of word-division to be distilled. The following seem well founded:

Words are separated from each other except for

- (1) single-letter proclitic particles (e.g. ׀, ׀, ׀)<sup>2</sup>
- (2) sometimes the *nota accusativi*
- (3) sometimes bound forms (construct+regnant noun, infinitive absolute+regnant verb)
- (4) sometimes the third person plural suffix.<sup>3</sup>

The discovery of deviations like the often-cited Lachish letter 3 with its apparent haplography (see § A 3 end) provides little basis for emendation of a biblical passage. Faults are rare in the majority of available documents. These facts should act as a control in the textual criticism of the Old Testament.<sup>4</sup>

<sup>1</sup> S. R. Driver, *Notes on the Hebrew Text... of the Books of Samuel* (2nd ed. Oxford, 1913), pp. xxvii-xxx; F. Buhl, *Canon and Text of the Old Testament* (Edinburgh, 1892), pp. 219-20; H. Bauer and P. Leander, *Historische Grammatik der Hebräischen Sprache* (Halle, 1922), p. 59; E. Würthwein, *The Text of the Old Testament* (Oxford, 1957), p. 73; M. Noth, *The Old Testament World* (London, 1966), p. 353.

<sup>2</sup> See already F. I. Andersen, *Or.* xxxv, 97, and the observations of Beeston on South Arabian, p. 12 n. 6 above.

<sup>3</sup> KAI 181 (Mesha Stele, 18); 202 A (Zakir Stele, 9); 217 (Bar Rakib fragment, 7), show separation of this suffix.

<sup>4</sup> After this study was written there appeared W. Watson's article "Shared Consonants in Northwest Semitic" (*Biblica* 1 (1969), 525-33), augmenting I. O. Lehman's work with further examples from the Old Testament and extra-biblical texts. Occasional clear examples of this practice, however, do not establish it as a norm, nor do they detract from the evidence, here presented, that word-division was customary in early Hebrew writing.